

Women in sports

Women's rise in sports in India has often been arduous with access and opportunities hard to come by. The Indian Railways have a stellar record at providing sporting opportunities to women and have made major strides in levelling the playing field for women in sports, including the more unconventional ones. For instance, the Northern Railway's Rachel Thomas became the first Indian woman to skydive on the North Pole in 2002 and the RSPB became one of the first organizations to encourage a women's wrestling team in India. More recently, wrestler Sakshi Malik brought bronze honours to India at the 2016 Rio Olympics.

Perhaps the best known is Pilavullakandi Thekkeparambil Usha, better remembered as PT Usha, who was nicknamed "Payyoli Express", the track and field athlete instrumental in taking Indian athletics to the world stage. Among others are Arjuna-awardee Dola Banerjee, sprinter Dutee Chand, cricketers Mithali Raj and Harmanpreet Kaur, and badminton player Madhumita Bisht. The Indian Railways' commitment to fostering female sporting talent can be attested by the fact that the Indian women's hockey team at the Rio 2016 Olympics comprised almost entirely of railway players, as was the 15-member Indian women's squad for the 2017 Women's Cricket World Cup, which had 10.